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Paper for the Environmental Anthropology Course of Elisabeth Tauber



Hunting in the Anthropocene

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“50 years ago, the *Osterbruch* territory was just meadows and cattle pastures.” A wave of nodding heads confirm the statement. Sitting around an oaken table in the farmhouses kitchen, I listen as the group of hunters lay out a brief summary about how the landscape has changed over time. The kitchen still looks the same as it did when I last saw it some years ago and it is actually not the first time that I hear this story. What is new, is that this time I’m taking notes. I’m told that the curlew (a large wading bird with a characteristic curved beak) lived here up until the 60s, in the 80s or 90s a third of the area was already transformed into fields for growing crops, and today – I know the place very well myself – almost the entire open land between the woods is intensively cultivated. Just in the northern part of the territory some places remained grassland. I eagerly listen to what the hunters have to say about this development, as I try to figure out how they respond to these changing landscapes in their hunting grounds.

Seven hundred kilometers further south, I return to the University of Bozen-Bolzano and join Elisabeth Tauber's environmental anthropology course. Listening to my professor share the experiences of alpine farmers in Tyrol, I immediately recognize overlaps with a conversation I’d had with one of the hunters who is also a farmer. Over the following months of the course, we explore indigenous relationalities, critically examine the *anthropocene*, and study multi-species anthropology. I'm surprised by how many aspects of these fields connect to my own experiences. Having obtained my license at age 16 and hunting mostly until about 20, I realize continuously how I draw lines between my late teenage years and the themes we are exploring in this course.

By engaging with environmental anthropology, I discovered a new language to articulate emotions and insights I had picked up during my time among the hunting community. The scholars in this field were describing and analyzing phenomena, some of which I had witnessed firsthand. I'm not trying to make an argument here that hunters generally make the same experiences as indigenous people, think like them, or carry multi-species sentiments, but I’m realizing that my personal way of relating to these topics seems to originate, in large part, from my past hunting experiences. For the research of my thesis project in eco-social design I therefore want to make use of the my *tacit knowledge* in the field of hunting and the connections I have to the community.

In the current phase of my research I ask the question how hunters' unique positionality shapes their responses to environmental change and biodiversity decline. In a broader sense, my thesis is situated in the context of our widespread alienation from the biological world around us – what indigenous scholars would call a *relational crisis*. Shaped by my anthropology coursework, my initial research question evolved from: *"What role does Hege play in nature protection in Germany?" to "How do hunters respond to changing landscapes in their hunting territories?"* paired with, the more design oriented follow-up question: *"Is Hege already – or how might it become – an embodied practice of reciprocity between hunters and the wildlife in their territories?"*

While reading “Coming Full Circle” I found an interesting aspect in McGregor’s description of Indigenous Knowledge (IK) that somehow connects to my own experiences of learning as a hunter. She argues that IK is not simply knowledge about relationships with creation, but rather “the relationship itself,” emphasizing that “it is the way that one relates” (McGregor, 2004). Throughout the text, she stresses that IK is active and embodied; it

cannot be understood as a body of accumulated information that can be acquired through study alone. Instead, it emerges through active engagement, and lived experiences within a certain place.

This idea resonated with what I have observed in my own process of acquiring hunters' knowledge. Hunters repeatedly immerse themselves in natural environments: they repeatedly go out into their territories where they sit silently, observing for hours or while stalking they even embody predatory animals quite literally. They constantly engage with the living world. They make these experiences again and again sometime over decades in the same landscape. For me this resulted in a deep relationship with the land and provided a major a source of my knowledge. While hunting you are not studying nature, you rather behave like a part of it. While the intention may ultimately be to kill, I would argue that the whole process is also about experiencing and understanding our natural surroundings.

McGregor's observation that knowledge continues to emerge through relationships with creation offers a hopeful outlook and could provide an interesting perspective for hunting. If hunters approach the natural world as attentive and receptive learners, the lessons they gain may resemble, in some ways, the forms of understanding that emerge from IK. In both cases, knowledge originates not only from instruction but also from ongoing engagement with the same teacher: Creation itself and the act of relating to it.

But what about the elephant in the room. How can it be that I talk about relationships to creation while it seemingly culminates in killing; in the destruction of creation itself? Before addressing the act of killing directly, I quickly want to give a quantitative perspective on hunting: The majority of hunting trips do not end with a kill. It sometimes takes five, ten, or more attempts until all factors align, allowing you to take the shot. It is very normal to spend countless hours, evenings, mornings, or entire nights in the field without shooting at all. In fact, this is often the norm. But I believe most hunters would agree that these trips are by no means wasted time. Instead they are rewarding moments spent outdoors at beautiful times of the day watching wild animals in their habitats.

Nevertheless, killing remains a recurring moment in a hunters life and can not be ignored. Surprisingly, anthropologist Thorsten Gieser (2025) points out that hunters actually don't talk a lot about the subject. However, I can recall a moment when the previously mentioned farmer had said something many years ago that seemed simple at first, but stayed with me until today: "They don't want to die". I tend to agree with Gieser that such honest reflections are rare. The topic is sensitive and the act of killing itself is a "problematic situation" (Gieser, 2025). Taking a life is never straightforward, especially in the unpredictable conditions of nature, where many factors are beyond human control. For me the moments leading up to a shot were often characterized by tension and stress. If everything proceeded as intended, the immediate feeling after killing was often relief rather than triumph, largely because I know what can go wrong and what suffering a bad shot can lead to.

While reading "the Honorable Harvest", I was struck by how Indigenous perspectives appear to engage much more directly with this paradox. Kimmerer (2013) reminds us that humans, like all animals, depend on the consumption of other living beings for survival. The problem of taking life is therefore not something that can simply be solved or

forgotten; rather, it is a condition of existence that requires ongoing ethical engagement. The principle of reciprocity offers one way of responding to this reality. Although the paradox remains, it is acknowledged and integrated into a broader framework of responsibility and gratitude.

Lastly I want to discuss another insight from the course that I got in form of multi-species anthropology in the context of the anthropocene. Picking up the terms and methodology of the Feral Atlas helped me to see a prominent topic among german hunters – that of wild boars and corn monocultures – through a fresh lens. Allowing an animal's point of view to enter our understanding of a landscape can fundamentally alter the way we understand and relate to it. And, as McGregor suggests, the way we relate shapes the way we act.

During my hunting education, I was taught that one explanation for the rapidly increasing wild boar populations is climate change, particularly milder winters with less snow, which improve piglet survival rates. Within today's hunting discourse, this has resulted in the dominant narrative that populations must be reduced through increased hunting pressure. In fact, boars are one of the few species with a year-round hunting season. However, boar population numbers continue to rise despite increasing harvest rates, making clear that this issue cannot be resolved by simply trying harder to kill more boars. Yet farmers call for hunters to fix the problem, which seems to nurture the feeling that they are not yet killing enough. This dynamic seems to have created a downward spiral of expectations and incentives, potentially encouraging ever more intense hunting practices and the erosion of ethical boundaries in an attempt to "solve" what is framed as an invasion.

By introducing corn through a multi-species perspective, the question shifts from how to kill more boars to how we have shaped the environments in which boars live. Across many hunting territories, vast monocultures provide an abundance of food and shelter. From a boar's perspective, these landscapes resemble ideal habitats: food is plentiful, cover is readily available, and survival becomes easier. What hunters and farmers often perceive as overpopulation, crop damage, or problematic behavior can therefore also be understood as a predictable response to environmental conditions that humans themselves have created. Yet frustration is frequently directed at the animals rather than at the landscapes that support them, leading to increasingly intensive hunting practices. In contrast, multi-species anthropology invites us to examine the broader relationships and the feral effects that produce these situations. Rather than responding solely through greater mobilization against wild boars, it offers the possibility to rethink the environments, responsibilities, and forms of coexistence that shape hunting territories in the Anthropocene.

Overall, the concepts and perspectives I encountered during the semester have been highly valuable for reflecting on hunting and my own experiences within these communities. Maybe hunters could even be particularly well positioned to engage with ideas of relationality, multi species perspectives, and reciprocity because of their direct and repeated encounters with animals and landscapes. This leaves me with several questions: Could *Hege* be reinterpreted through Indigenous understandings of responsibility and care? Could hunters communicate their relationships with animals and landscapes differently if these ideas were taken into account? If we imagine what hunting will be like in the future, what forms of reciprocity, stewardship, and accountability should accompany it?

Literature

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